

Watchlist 7/15

- The wind rises
- The umbrellas of Cherbourg
- Zodiac
- The Illusionist
- Ten Things I hate about you
- Mr. Plankton
- The social hotel
- Pan's Labyrinth
- Goodwill Hunting
- In the Mood for Love
- The last of us
- 12 Angry men
- The Godfather
- Neon Genesis Evangelion
- Your lie in April
- The dictator

July 2026

Eternal sunshine of the spotless mind 8.9/10

- Messily perfect in every way.
- I think the audience is very hit or miss. I see it for (1) people who just had/have a romantic relationship, (2) someone recently going through an emotionally vulnerable or reflective time, and (3) people with close ones in their lives moving on.
- Prior expectations: Whoever labeled the movie as a comedy drama is a really funny gaslighter. I had an entirely different conception coming in: a perfect sentimental romance like Lalaland, but instead of "right person, wrong time," I was thinking more regret and the impossibility of reconciliation?
- "what did you like about it?" asks Nivi. Well, I first need to braindump my generic ideas before delving personal: details often matter more than concepts.
- - I think the title is PERFECT.
- - Elijah Wood? Mark Ruffalo? HELLO? I did not expect this.
- - Also, I did not know it was going to be psychological or even a bit dark: at some point I was even wondering whether it was a horror film T-T. Sigh. I went in to see a beautiful relationship and a sentimental ending, completely unprepared for the messy realities of repression, life, and relationships . . . but IT'S SO unexpectedly messily perfect like life. The dialogue clearly serves the purpose of capturing both the intimacy and humiliation.
- - the start and some parts are even a bit nonsensical, but it's like the irrational things we do for the people we love. Also, I did suspect the beginning sequence as I was watching, but it still hit extremely hard (eternal sunshine . . .). The repetition scenes are nice calls to the eternal-ness aspect for sure.

- I think this: Lalaland perfectly explores a relationship from formation to conflict and sentimental finality while Eternal Sunshine perfectly, realistically, rawly, and subjectively explores it from the end.
- Elijah Wood as Patrick, yes, is a shitty person for sure, but I do think that he loves Clementine, and that's a statement as well: I think he tries to steal Joel's identity because he's worried that she would not love him for who he really was (Obsession?), and that's very real as well. Prepackaging is a concept I've been thinking a lot about recently . . .
- The only part I felt was a bit unnecessary is Mary's love for the doctor: the only purpose I could see here is to show that the case is not limited to Joel and Clementine, but come on!! That came at a crucial moment and did it really add much to the story's meaning? Happy to be corrected.
- I think it's also somewhat fkin mental (a bit extrapolative but hear me out) to also convince the viewer the conception of Clementine as eccentric, impulsive, goofball-y, and cute like what Joel likely wanted her to be for him; however, near the end, his perspective, and the viewers', is changed for sure.
- It's also weird. My Beaver mentor said today that sometimes people are really bad at theorizing why they feel a way: they say one thing that they even fully believe in themselves, but it is not true in the emotions and decisions of the moment they try explaining.
- I think it's good enough to just choose something you personally resonate with but continue diagnosing that reality you accept! And note to self: rewatch this movie whenever I feel like I fit the audience again! But actually it's so good I think I'll just rewatch it tomorrow.
- Lastly, I think my pre-thoughts was that the "spotless mind" is a positive symbol of peace and moving on, but now, it seems to just "show the pores in the face of life"-- it's hard to handle expression, therefore repression or anesthesia (?). Very nice quote: "Yet somehow we think we can grow, feeding on flowers and fireworks, without completing the cycle back to reality."

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The Big Short 8.1

- I love ryan gosling (and christian bale)
- Honestly the movie really helps simplify the jargon of corporate finance and makes it understandable and enjoyable through simpler terminology. Also the actors explaining the terms were very comedic lol: was ALEX HONNOLD in the movie?
- Probably one of the first movies I've seen breaking the fourth wall, and it makes sense here!!! It constantly reminds me that it is a real story and adds a nice storytelling layer.
- There's a lot of exposee and muckraking (ahhh) here, but this is also one of the reasons why I think APUSH (and this movie) is so interesting: there's always a lot of repackaging of human greed and capitalism of prior times into new forms like the housing industry responsible for the 2008 depression.
- The ending suggests a continuation despite what happens and some people having righteous internal compasses. Even though some do the right thing, people still die. I

think the argument though is that we live in a society where we still must choose the uncomfortable decision to “be decent men in an indecent time.” It will pay off eventually.

- Should a takeaway be to villainize bankers (and crooks), to idolize people like Mark Baum? I don't think so. There's greed, disgust, leeches, and dehumanization in any career we may take, and though it could be our dream, I think most of us will find our paths narrower than we expect: that is something we may have to swallow; there still a lot of beauty left to savor anyways. There's a lot of incentives.
- Tocqueville: “Egotism blights the germ of all virtue; individualism, at first, only saps the virtues of public life; but, in the long run, it attacks and destroys all others, and is at length absorbed in downright egotism.”
- I think the Big Short demonstrates this. Our democracy creates a condition where our social conditions are inherently unstable: you have to strive for your place in the hierarchy. Every person is born in a social and economic precarity. Because of this, individualists have no choice but to place their status above everything. This can also explain many of our schools' rat races and immoralities.

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American Psycho 8.3/10

- No comment.
- Probably one of the few movies I went to believing in a pre-determined five stars, but I don't know about it anymore.
- A person with a hedonistic homicidal radius with an apt for pre-wrapping?
- Themes of toxic masculinity, rat racing, and is probably reflected in some people's real identity, a bit in myself, though not this extreme of course. Self-pompousity . . .
- Pretty nice satire with the business cards and superficiality. Personally, I'm less excited toward societal critique movies currently, but there's some new nuggets for both the individual and society here.
- I think his aim to fit in and distilled LinkedIn-speak feels soooo derivative of social media sometimes. It's interesting the idea of growing up rich. Like the changing construct of the American Dream, it is interesting what talking to people who have it differently are imo: perhaps in an alternate, his self-vanity or bleeding of erraticness would have been directed towards creative pursuits.
- The societal critiques are nice, but not unseen without literature or movies. The idea that all of this could have been his fantasy from the alienation of society is nice though.
- I need to return to Ghibli. This is too intense for me.
- also THAT's where the one meme came from.
- Shit I lowkey see some parts of him in myself, albeit only a little. There's no Catharsis.
- I need to explore more ideas on what is after self-discovery, discovering that there's really no true you, and what there is to do with that. Trying to find an objective foundation of yourself is just meaningless, but sulking after discovery does not matter, I think that's what Bateman ends with, a society that is indifferent to his actions and himself, who seems to realize there's really no line for himself.

- After diagnosis, is it an intuitive problem of breaking down a path forward, like a muscle-up with 3 different steps, or also an emotional feel. Not what you see, but what you feel?
- Good movie. Pessimism is respectable but never lovable though . . .
- Something about his fantasizing of literary works and musical artists work after or during a killing just gives the vibe that he finds it so enjoyable. MILK AND SERIAL.

June 2026

Dr. Strangelove or: How I learned to stop worrying and love the bomb 8/10

- Well, I think any historical piece should somewhat be considered through the lens of the conditions of the time. Here, largely marked by immunological hysteria and M.A.D.
- Well-defined characters of the president resembling FDR/Truman, ambassador being fat is intentional as well IMO. From the perspective of the American audience at the time, I wonder if it is a baby step of feeding into expectations or biases of Russians as fat and Germans as crazy, then portraying the president's call with Dmitri as mutual with a purpose of showing like "shit we are in this together type" message. Really subtle messaging along with some olden music, somewhat wistfully in the beginning like a "nothing really matters" ah. Also the plane captain's hat kind of just reminds me of a cowboy, like Americans dropping themselves dead for the sake of killing Russians as well, and disguising that as freedom. Clever or maybe I'm extrapolating.
- A lot of nice historical prevalence like conspiracies or distrust and GAPS. The scientist being an optimizer was also interesting. I can't remember the history anymore, but perhaps it is a poke at equating the war effort to the crazed scientist: a subtle equating of the optimization of Nuclear warheads and closing the "gap" as similar to what Hitler would think, it is entirely devoid of humanity. It's like using science as an objective rhetoric to mask insecurity.
- Lastly, the comedy was quite nice and satirical: the people were uncannily composed even though the world may have been ending lol. Clear stakes but almost ridiculed even.
- Honestly I kind of liked that, it sort of shifts me back externally from heavily introspective movies and history is always interesting. It also gives me a comedy vibe of Grand Budapest Hotel with sensitive war topics.
- I wonder if engagement is a "Gen Z" issue or an actual critique I have of the movie.

Tenet 7.6

- Probably the most extreme case example of Nolan's style of messing with time.
- What I think happened (briefly to collect my thoughts)
 - Sator and Arepo (possibly a time traveler) were making deals for inverted objects with the goal of destroying the world on Sator's death with the Algorithm.
 - Protagonist is both the person controlling all the events from the future to have his past self succeed, but also the person moving through current events being led by Neil, who is somewhat like a mentor that has already gone through everything as well.
- Why it works

- A very unique concept tied behind some physics, though the reality of time inversion feels less attainable than Inception.
- Action sequences were always puzzling yet insane as well, with the car flips but inverted halves: the audience must pay very close attention while marveling at all the little paradoxes forming. I think I roughly paid enough attention? Not sure.
- Quite interpretative again of what you may want to take from the film I feel like. I saw that reality is very messy, unpredictable, and possibly contradictory, but we must govern ourselves on tenets to move through.
- How the hell did they film this.
- Why it doesn't work as well
 - Nolan is great at characters that need compensation, but the characters were somewhat weak here. Sator feels somewhat like a cliché tiger villain (reminds me of Larry Ellison "everyone around me must fail"). Kat's motivations are entirely around protecting the child from Sator. Then, the Protagonist is heavily shielded from backstory.
 - Confusing, but I think I get a good portion?
- Hmm, I didn't really find what I was really looking for here. Dreams and Identity . . .

Inception 8.6/10

- I think I have finally found a cooking Mr. Nolan films, most of his I've watched were good but not great...
- Why it works
 - I mean the cinematography in general is insane. The many small details like Cobb paralleling the people in the den and action sequences is insane.
 - The core idea of multi-player dreams tied to real concepts like subconscious, gut over facts, reality, or dreams feeling longer is so enticing in general, somewhat escapist yet "possible," which satisfies the creative side.
 - This just ties into worldbuilding I guess, and everything felt very cohesive in this regard, so vast, yet logical, paradoxical, and interpretive.
 - Nolan really knows how to create characters that need compensation: possibly obsessed or driven, but damaged emotionally like here or the Prestige, or a literal mental defect like Memento. The characters again, were extremely solid with Cobb as the core and Ariadne as a foil.
 - I honestly wanted to rewatch this because of Perfect Blue: the subconscious is a very vast space for interpretation, but it is also like planting an idea, which may have cancerous results. It is easy for people and myself to become enticed with one interpretation or plan of pursuit, or even one view of oneself with psychoanalysis, like prepackaging. Inception expands on this idea I've been interested in exploring through projections and layers of dreams. "You keep telling yourself what you know. But what do you believe? What do you feel?"
 - This core idea of inspiration through planting, paired with exceptional worldbuilding, character-building, you get a highly stimulating and thought-provoking piece.

- Nolan's Dark Knight felt cliché, but I did not feel it as much here, maybe just the Stormtrooper aim of the enemies was a bit forced but that's necessary. The ending is very Nolan-like, ending on an unconventional-manner. It is quite iconic.
- Escapism is an interesting aspect of the motivation for dreams. Every once in a while, I watch for engagement and less for meaning (like Perfect Blue), but Inception really provided some of both for me.
- Some dialogue could have been more implicit, but it makes sense from an audience standpoint to appeal. I personally lean towards more emotional subtext or afterglow, but this was the right balance of action as well. I can't really think of any flaws. I finally find a top Nolan movie yay.

Perfect Blue 8.7/10

- Absolute mindfudge like Memento or Curry Barker's works: I wonder if this was even an inspiration for him . . . The more I think, the deeper it gets.
- Why it works
 - Blurring of reality and Mimi's subconscious really dismantles any sense of stability. Ultimately, this unreliable foundation really sets up the horror / psychological aspect well, and provides the mindfudge that feels uniquely mysterious. Also quite rewarding for a careful viewer, as I could sometimes tell through the fishes or lapses in her name as well.
 - SO creative in the transitions. You really feel like a mental health patient lol.
 - Raw gore or its adult murder mystery vibe was a bit too raw for me, but again, I still feel horror is a useful path to some very intense personal insecurities and social commentaries. The "obsessive" themes and critiques of industry felt really potent because of this, and you can also interpret it from ALOT of angles because of all its confusion
- For future Max whenever I rewatch
 - Me-mania and Mima -> identity, specifically my debate with Carson if you remember. When I give AI context of who I am, does AI then become my stalker? I mean from the perspective of an observer, Me-Mania never really knows "Mima", but only her objective actions and then he projects his "ideas of her." What are the implications when an AI (who "knows" you), or any friend, tells me who "I am?" Could every perspective be somewhat right, yet under the surface, it's still a mess: I feel uncomfortable to know myself to the point that, less than an easily handled stalker interpretation, I feel that I must become the sum of all its projections? It has been peculiar this summer thinking of who I am because I just am who I am but I also must write about who I am and how I think. I feel a similar DID to Mima, but of course I'm not imagining myself falling apart yet (t-t). Mima's doll feels really robotic and filtered. It's like some of my choices to mold into a "not not." Aren't our lives like a performance, who is the audience? I can relate to that. Of course, I do not think there's a foundation to Mima or myself, but we are the sums of our various pieces. I wonder what I will think in a couple of months. PREPACKAGING.
 - I honestly did not care too much for the movie's societal critique: like discovering poverty exists but being so emotionally stirred in the moment as to not care.

- Questions to myself
 - Ever since I got a Letterboxd, are my reviews less “me” in terms of my audience? Is this question even addressed to my future self, or someone out there or both (I think both now)? WHAT DOES THAT EVEN MEAN to being a continuous person (am I the sum of my choices)? REMEN THE TRUTH OF FACT, AND THE TRUTH OF FEELING.
 - My brain is gone right now.

Parasite 8/10

- Noted: caution against bringing large fortune-bringing rocks into the house.
- Noted x2: start using “charlatan” instead of “larp” as terminology . . .
- Wow. Social classes at play with the upper class and Global South. I went in expecting nothing new to be honest from other literature (Death of a Salesman, Grays Ferry, Witch hunts, Omelas, etc.), so more for entertainment.
- While I still think that, I would say it was done really well.
- First off, the cinematography was very careful. Whenever the family goes to Park’s house, they walk upstairs, and going home, they walk downstairs. It is a likely thought out mannerism, but realizing this early made me watch the scenes more closely.
- Belittlement was not exactly what I initial thought of from social discrimination: I expected more pity and scapegoating, so this was quite fresh imo.
- Something about the brother saying the sister “fits in” with the rich life and being the only dead family member unsettles me.
- Were they going somewhere with the theme of plans?
- The dual interpretation of rain was nice, but a clear cut poke to me. I think smell is more interesting as an anchor meant to portray the family and Global South in general: limited mobility.
- The basement dude’s line on how he feels comfortable reminded me of Shawshank’s “institutionalized.” so metaphorical....
- Opinionated: The ending almost restarts for the son, with no socio-economic progression, but morally I think he pictures a less-parasitic path? I feel he does just state he will make a lot of money, so not entirely sure: it’s a bit ambiguous whether there is much progression, IN A good way.
- Hmm I thought I was going to rate this much higher.

Milk and Serial 7.5/10

- What if your friend was a serial killer? When does love become an obsession? What is the allure of progress or mastery? What happens when your identity as public and private infrastructure becomes only public? What happens when toxicity or virality is normalized?
- Easy to follow, simple, and somewhat scary.
- Amazing for an 800 dollar budget (wait this is actually insane), nothing too special, but interesting as an afternoon watch.
- Gradual buildup from something expected, to disturbing. Baby steps of a dual interpretation of the same media.

2081 Harrison Bergeron 6.5/10

- A nice satire of total equality versus individualism

- There wasn't as much "craziness" around Bergeron's dance, which was a major point of Kurt's purpose, so I did not really like it as much. It was supposed to be a critique of both extremes, but the film does that less well.

Kiki's Delivery Service 8.2/10

- A very simple and absolutely charming movie
- A coming of age, teen tinges of romance, and themes of finding your place in the world and inherent good in people.
- I forgot how peaceful and beautiful Ghibli is.
- I love Jiji and how maybe Kiki can't speak with the cat anymore but still keep each other company.
- The ideas of upward comparison, passion becoming stale, and unexpected altruism are all quite simple and there is nothing new here, but it is so charming and I'm absolutely smiling through any part of this movie.
- The music is calming sunshine on a plate.
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Backrooms 7.5/10

- I really liked the idea of the backrooms remembering everything but distorted and how it remembers in its own twisted way.
- Good worldbuilding
- The environment is really unique as well. It is interesting how it is designed. The characters are quite strong as well, the dude which was somewhat emotionally broken and "stuck," which is quite common, and the Therapist who is somewhat hypocritical and has worries of her own despite preaching good will.
- The scene where Pirate Clark was reaching for her was nice, since we see the Entities desperation for her help but also maybe bro just looks like that in general.
- The movie was more about exploring the Backrooms than a cohesive plot point, there is so much left unanswered, so I think a sequel would be nice here.
- The horror itself is quite nice, though Obsession was much better.

The Dark Knight Rises 7.8/10

- It started quite cliché/forced to me imo. The Joker felt like just a sociopath without his intentions clearly stated, except that perhaps his dad beat him up or his wife left him?
- The acting was really phenomenal though, and Joker's quite insane; this is also paralleled in Wayne's surveillance of 30 million people: common themes of justice and vengeance or love and hate having blurred lines, thought of some philosophy and ethics while watching this ahhh.
- Harvey was really something, Joker's worldview being both correct (in Harvey's descent from white knight to broken soul) and wrong (in the social experiment) is quite an interesting dynamic. Thought of Hellhole's subclaim (elite people still suffer in solitary): MAX remember this. A once reserved man spiraling into stochasticity.
- A main theme I felt from the movie is a man's strivance at a decent life within an indecent world, and the coin landing on heads for the commissioner at the end somewhat illustrates it is the strivance worth fighting for in society. I really liked that quote.

- I can't help but feel that some parts felt dualistic, yet complex at the same time. Heads or Tails, Hero or villain. I liked how Wayne stated he was neither, and that worked for me.
- Lastly, the quotes were quite cliché, "not the hero we needed, but the hero we deserve," "live to see yourself become the villain" ahhh. Joker feels less like a foil, but a mirror image that's slightly distorted: Wayne if he did not succeed.
- THE ACTION WAS INSANE.
- Overall, the movie did not really reveal something novel or evoke some emotion I thought was special (Grand Budapest Hotel), so while it was really good, Nolan's movies are always good, I didn't find it exceptional, top 3 movie types. Maybe my expectations were too high.

Grand Budapest Hotel 8/10

- An exotic, quirky, and eccentric gem that I never knew existed, but am glad that I discovered
 - Feels like choosing a random book at the library type and uncovering a whole story of someone you never met but come to understand and adore.
- Beautiful storytelling and recording style. Gustave is like a father figure to Zero, and the light-hearted comedy continually creates a palatable tone as opposed to a possibly dark family-feud angle instead. Quite artistic in my opinion as well and really original, feels exactly like reading a novel.
- The characters are built well, Gustave is somewhat lonely before Moustafa came into his life, and he is also quite precise, humorous, and obviously has a desire for "richer" connection (he likes how Agatha has purity), hence his love towards older folk (people become naturally "richer" as they get older???)??? Maybe I'm rambling.
- The music selection is quite wistful and floating, and I really love how the audience is lowkey us: the girl reading the book is the viewer, and the narrator is the guy hearing the story from Moustafa.
- Renaissance + European type vibes from Boy with Apple and the general dialogue feel. Hella nice tbh like ppl speaking French. Nice quoting, a bit whimsical tied behind a compelling story arc.
 - "there are still faint glimmers of civilization left in this barbaric slaughterhouse"
- Honestly, to end, the movie was quite strange, and I do not believe I truly captured my thoughts, but that is the quirkiness of the GRAND BUDAPEST HOTEL and I LOVE IT. Thanks Phillip.

Obsession 8.7/10

- HOLY FUCK. That was scary as shit.
- The premise is so simple yet it was more complex than I initially believed.
 - Nikki can snap out of it and we see that it is not even her true self.
 - Bear's quite narcissistic/hopeless romantic
 - The ending was quite tragic, yet innocent. Bear dies loving Nikki, and Nikki lives realizing her life is ruined. I really liked it.
- He cannot see himself in the mirror (the mirror is blurred) until he realizes the differences between romance and love: when he realizes he needs to cancel his wish, not alter it.

- This is a goated introduction to horror ngl; good atmosphere, not really a dependence on jumpscars and the acting was perfect!
- There's quite a lot of subtle foreshadowing like Nikki's notes, and her snapping out, and well-placed characters like Grace (collateral), and Ian (the dependable friend type). One way love? Bear-Grace, Bear-Nikki.
- There's also some dramatic irony; like we knew grace was going to fkin die and possibly Ian. Also you're always scared she's going to snap or do some weird watching you sleep type shi that you are cuddled in bed that night.

May 2026

Age of Ultron 7.2/10

- "Something is not beautiful because it lasts"
- Well, the movie honestly reminds me pretty much of how our modern society may play out. Order and chaos, perhaps the researcher who discovers AGI for good intention instead destroys the world.
- Could be really worrying who is building these tools -> Altman?
- Marvel movies in general are so hype, I forgot how much I loved superheroes.
- The ending is quite cliché (wow perfect ending), but the movie itself is done quite well. Getting chills ngl Jarvis controlling other AI, the mind stone representing an idealized version. I feel like this movie aged quite well, maybe not as great a few years back.
- Quite nice the insecurities of each character, but there is always some concern imo of movies around a large group of different characters: each one does not feel too explored in depth. Iron Man felt explored slightly better.
- The Natasha Bruce thing felt a bit eh, I mean both are outcasts which is why they "love" each other is alright.
- It's quite brilliant that both Ultron and Vision are not necessarily wrong, actually I sympathize with both viewpoints.

Catch me if you can! 8.6/10

- Daddy issues projected into son and tragic family result quite nice reminded me of Miller
 - Frank basically reflected his father's lessons and preaching.
- Very iconic + Leonardo DiCaprio's is such a great actor of course.
- A bit exaggerated I feel, but really nice along with the sacrifices like his marriage.
- Karl/Carl is a foil in a sense that he didn't lie about the police, and felt more like a friend/father figure to Frank than an enemy.
- Hustle culture and pinstripes is so real man. Frank's superficiality came tumbling down later on. Lesson: so probably build some form of permanent aura?
 - Carl is basically the opposite again because he has no "aura," but he is a real FBI agent. It does perhaps show the cons of both extremes as well, since Frank is quite a tragic character and isolated but became rich from faking it (RIP MARRIAGE) while Carl barely had the chance to visit her daughter. Meet in the middle?
- Also sort of about discovering your own identity and believing in people again (redemption), as shown when Frank believes Carl has the police outside and also in the girl. Frank did turn that cream into butter from his experiences with his final job with the FBI.

- Amazing tension/drama and had me nervous for Frank, as well as rooting for Karl. Both characters have reasonable motivations, and it feels the main source of conflict was the dad.
- Important motifs like the bar exam and again the butter quote which show Frank is capable of a better life, but he is hopelessly stuck in his father's ideologies. Tom and Jerry ah.

Michael 7.2/10

- "Not really a story, more like a memory" - Carson
- It felt like I was in a concert.
- Michael as a character felt shallow. Okay . . . he just liked animals and affirmations? There should be more to that. Felt too simple like he just had a stressful dad and that was the main obstacle he had to overcome.
- Some quotes were quite nice.
- The dancing is spot on!

Trust and Betrayal 9/10

- rewatch thoughts: was actually quite a slow burner until the third episode, where the imminent developments really start tying together and become both tragic, haunting, and beautiful all at the same time . . .
- episode 1
simplistic in Kenshin's motivations as I felt before, but the art and music is still striking and sentimental. A slower start than I remembered, but a solid introduction and echoing ending. Feels a bit philosophic on the inner-psyche of Kenshin.
- episode 2. a lot of necessary development. The plot thickens . . . It is a tragedy imo that Kenshin fights for the mere idea of justice without knowing whether it is, or is not. But there's a lot of nice symbolism here with the sheath, top, and scenery colors.
- episode 3 really cements this as one of my favorite films of all time. The coloring and subtlety of Tomoe's actions or dialogue, and the general tragedy and sacrifice of both parties is heart-wrenching and conditional.
- episode 4 the best prequel to any show I will ever watch, even if I ever watch another prequel. the music is so powerful. two conflicted lovers caught in the midst of the processualities of shogun politics were worth every minute of the earlier episodes, and perfectly concludes this chapter of Kenshin's life, moving forward from his childhood yet bearing the scars and scarf of Tomoe. Hmm... his final dialogue with Tomoe still strikes me as a bit off though . . . but definitely I am keeping this at a 5/5
- perfect example of how animation as a medium itself can often more easily express some of the subtleties of emotion and inner-conflict more vividly and abstractly than possibly normal camera film
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- Easily one of the best unique art styles and perfect fitting, chilling music.
- Holding onto humanity and continuation of struggle with Tomoe as sheath and strength
- Case study into a singular character during a broader conflict.
- Perfect ideation and execution, never felt rushed, except several characters felt like filler and a bit of dialogue felt out of character to me.
- Beautiful artwork and felt like a chapter of Kenshin's character.

- Red color tones choices and thoughtful flashbacks showed inner tension well. Ending is satisfying just some fluff since it was setting up the main anime.
- I would not have the main anime and keep it as a sequel.
- Good symbolism, top and bleeding.
- Tragedy and Sacrifice.
- "I will protect you"

Memento 8/10

- "I need to look at the eyes of who I am talking to"
- But the whole time he wanted to look into the eyes of himself. Clever flashing of Sammi and himself and also Sammi's hesitation. It is not that he is pretending, I think he truly has a condition, but that he was lying to himself this whole time to keep his life's purpose. Burning the evidence.
- The Dodd and Natalie aspect of the show seemed a bit more like filler though, but the general rhetorical choice of non-linear storytelling is done skillfully and it feels that I am part of the mystery, there are also good moments of dramatic irony or skillful interweaving of scenes. So many small details that give away the time like car windows, suits, and more.
- The truth hurts more like closing your eyes. there seems to be something more I didn't fully grasp yet.
- SOoooo original despite simple choices, I just haven't seen a movie like this before.
- Remember Sammi Jankis
 - Warning to himself.
- Feeling of victim versus perpetrator of own tragedy.

April 2026

Truman Show 7.9/10

- Very interesting like societal conditioning to follow a set path.
- Hard freedom/free will versus comfortable safety.
- Fighting against conformity in a society where people and hurdles constantly impede your path.
- The ending is quite nice in that the Creator's worldview is destroyed. He thinks that people cannot break free and Truman is too scared, but he does.
- Some motifs like "how does it end" button actually make sense
- Very creative in general of the reality TV vibe and is something I haven't seen before.
- The father just disappeared afterwards and it seemed like a return to normal, but he was actually planning to leave the whole time.
- The Cinematography Creator feels like Steve Jobs.
- The relationship felt a bit unnecessary, only as an inciting event, but the people do show cultures around the world impacted by him.

Full Metal Alchemist 9

- Episode 1 was already a banger ngl. We see king Bradley hiding something, there's a lot of secrets which clues me in perfectly. Gluttony and someone else at the end. Alphonse and Edward committed some taboo. There's too much unclear that makes me want to keep watching. Mystery of storytelling.

- 2-3 Backstory of the taboo. The world feels very rule-based and believable currently. The joke of his height is getting a bit old, but I do see it makes him not a perfect person. The relationship and music is quite haunting. I didn't remember the show to have this much humor yet moments of maturity. I never remembered it for much humor.
- The story survives on unanswered questions currently.
- Nina and Tucker. Case stories in each episode tug at our heart strings
- Others who have committed taboo
- It isn't a fully phenomenal story yet, but let's keep watching it while living on unanswered questions.
 - To stay human.
- Puppet twists are nice. It feels like always edging us though.
- The innocence of new life.
- All is one, one is all.
- Interesting dramatic irony king bradley
- Eds dad this plan?
- Xing is interesting. Xerxes is cool as well.
- Mental resilience in times of pain. Mama don't cry
- Protect vs something to kill with
- The lore is deep.
- **W WORLD BUILDING**

Shawshank Redemption 8.4/10

- That was beautiful: for the briefest of moments, every last man in Shawshank felt free.
- The old man sets up the Institutionalized meaning well.
- It is almost as if Andrew is a free man in jail, like a caged bird.
- The warden feels dualistic, but it shows the intersection of human greed and sanctimony.
- The student, his death, is the jolt. Ultimately, I felt less for his relation than the development of the Warden.
- Red and Andrew. A fkin perfect narrator. FRIENDSHIP
- Also revealing that escape towards the end. Does something make us idolize him though? Mythic
- Andrew is a very "too himself" type of person. The ending is peaceful, felt Frieren vibes of the twos friendship and camaraderie.
- The revenge itself is quite satisfying, and the parallelism of Brookes then Red felt unforced, along with the repetition of Red's rehabilitation decision. "To feel like a free man, even for a moment."
- Andy Dufresne - who crawled through a river of shit and came out clean on the other side.
- Holding onto your humanity
- Cons:
 - The stakes towards the end of him hanging versus escaping at first feels unnecessary, but honestly illustrates the busy living or dying point, good on them?
 - The Robert Frost letter to Red felt a bit unnecessary, but it gave Red a purpose to live for.

- Andrew helping out with fraud to further his own purpose? Not sure how I felt. He's not a perfect man, he's a loner, but he truly cared for his friends: library, student teaching, beer. It's like institutions, you have to have patience. SO I really have no flaws with the movie that I feel are unnecessary!

The boys Season 5

- Episode 1
 - "I do it for them"
 - A-train death was really well-crafted. Homelander insecurities are nice.
 - The introduction put me right into the action. Butcher killing his dad felt a bit unnecessary: paint him as cold?
 - We honestly get Homelander's ego and fragileness, but it felt a bit too direct the way of painting it this Season. The new GenZ appeal is something indeed.
- Episode 2
 - Viruses are much more interesting now. I would have thought his death is rushed but now the moral complexity is deeper
 - Each episode has been wild so far.
- Fall off is wild.

Project Hailmary 7.9/ 10

- very stunning visuals; ryan gosling humor is nice (in a good way).
- The main relationship was unexpected; as Carson says: it's like meeting someone from a foreign country. It is a bit cliché (dynamic isn't new, but is done well and is sincere)
- The choice of layering was thoughtful, very creative.
- Cons: A did not understand a few shoved motifs; the circumvention of death felt a bit downplayed and detracted from the immersion, but the overall lightheartedness imo was the right move, simply: the falling action seemed unpolished, but still satisfying.
 - Given my first impression of gosling from lalaland, I had higher expectations for the music: it was average. cinematic sci-fi adventure, grand :/
- Last thoughts: A breath of fresh air. Easy to understand stakes (even though I'm tired, it was a ride)
- Grace's "love" seemed just like filler.
- "Find a friend who is so different from you, you can't believe how much you have in common." (Nye)

March 2026

Frieren Season 1 9/10

- The music is gentle, calm, and warming. It makes you revisit your relationships with your friends with a kinder light.
- The first episode is everything that destroys the trope I expected, and the starry night is beautiful
- Stark's personality is beautiful: to be a coward but to be able to fight for your friends
- Life's fleeting nature
- Old Man Voll is my favorite episode because of Frieren's development and emotional depth, the music is fking fleeting and brilliant
- The flashbacks hit hard man

- The mage exam was hype but not the main part of the story
- Frieren Season 2 8/10
 - It's still gentle, calm, and warm. Each episode feels short and fleeting, but done well. There were just less parts that stood out to me, yet each episode left the same beauty of the first season to me.
 - Stark looked at his hand and fought for the homeland of others, bohsaft being found and enjoyed by the town.
 - The artwork is beautiful.

LalaLand 8.7/10

- Felt like a creative artwork where it came together at the end.
- The ending was something special I feel like. The rest of the story was also really candid + heartwarming.
- Felt a bit similar to Whisper of the Heart, but in an adult view and non-animated of course; Look back ending is similar as well. If I did not watch the other two, my score would be much higher.
- The music is definitely goated, not going to lie, and there is something about the vibe of the movie that feels unique and cultural?
- +00000000 points for J.K. Simmons
- I did not feel too into the movie in the first half. A bit too expressive
- The themes are quite touching as a high schooler trying to find my place in the world
- Definitely an all-timer. Emotional resonance is deep.

Back To The Future 8.7/10

- Iconic
- Flashy, Stakes + Humor
- Classic. Songs are great. Earth Angel, Earth Angel
- The casting roles are great and the storyline is cohesive, I like the concept.
- I hope the sequels do it justice.
- Doc and Marty are a duo man
- All-timer

Back To The Future 2 7.5/10

- The best parts were the first movie parts.
- 2015 didn't hit too well. The new family was hella weird as well so I guess they just didn't predict well? Some parts of it were okay I guess. The plot is definitely a bit mishmashed.
- The 1985 part with rich Biff was a bit weird
- The CHICKEN part is just stupid ngl; like why?
- The 1955 part was pretty much perfect imo.
- The emotional depth is my main liking of movies, but this one for escapism and entertainment is done well.

Back To The Future 3 7.8/10

- Finally got through that dumb Chicken thing
- I really liked Doc's character development. Tension was definitely there. I guess Doc is just a genius?
- A good ending to this masterpiece.
- I couldn't ask for anything else

- The start of hill valley.
- Everything back to normal; Clint Eastwood a living legend!
- Where was Doc going?
- Tanen is like a villain across time. Biff seems like such a nice guy now.
- Little details. Lea Thompson scene.
- The little details I did catch. Downsides?
 - I like how it was completely different because another repeat would be stale. In another world for 2 hours.
 - Elizabeth Shue is hell a useless bro.
- **Adding recurring patterns is rewarding for a long-time watcher. STORYTELLING**
- Beginning was a bit of a hard watch but I really liked towards middle + end

WarGames 7.4/10

- A bit escapist and unrealistic
- One of a kind in another sense
- Cybersecurity "Let's play Global Thermonuclear War"
- The only winning move is not to play.
- The dynamic was interesting for sure. A bit mythic of high schooler hacking into US security systems.

February 2026

Look Back 7.7/10

- Cherishing your friends and close-ones, because at the end of the day, the memories are much more special than the petty grudges.
- Attention to detail; Symbolism (the 4 panels)
- Why do we create art?
- Social precarity
- Look back to move forward . . .
- Cons:
 - A bit idealistic
 - A bit cramped; time skips were too frequent for my liking.
 - Tropes/Cliche + I KNEW KYOMOTO was gonna die! The hand holding felt fleeting. But the literal "look back" if she never drew that panel was surprisingly emotive to me.
 - If I think about it, Lalaland ending feels similar to Look Back

The Prestige 8.2/10

- Unparalleled cinematic magic
- Sheer dedication and Christopher Nolan is honestly cracked for this
- "Are you watching closely?"
- The dedication to your craft.

The Imitation Game 7.2/10

- Sometimes it's the very people who no one imagines anything of who do the things that no one can imagine.
- But remove the satisfaction, and the act becomes... hollow.
- Humanizing one who is "gay" or considered different than others.

- Amazing the character development across the story, and "Christopher" in general.
- The twist where they couldn't release it entirely because then Germans would just switch Enigma; caught me there.
- Cons:
 - Aura moments; lowkey not like probably what happened. Heightened for appeal
 - Unclear why when they built it, they didn't know it would take too long.
 - Little details seem like a huge break, but I feel it might not have happened that way.

January 2026

Whisper of the heart 7.6/10

- Heart-warming and also just carried by the one soundtrack
- Themes of finding yourself and your own voice, themes of first love and innocence.
- The baron was kinda cool

Spirited Away 8.7/10

- Nice societal themes, whimsical
- The music is really nice for sure
- It was a very good watch, and it was super creative.
- Good soundtrack is cornerstone to a movie I like it seems
- But the general themes and storyline was innocent, and again, whimsical

December 2025

Grave of the Fireflies 9.1/10

- An emotional masterpiece, does more as an anti-war film than any movie I have watched.
- Motif of the candy and realism and the rhetorical choice of the red tint and "blank eyes"
- As well as the imagery and trauma of innocence lost. "Busy distraction" to ignore from the reality of wars
- 500 miles
- Rock paper scissors with self, alone. Sacrifice
- Pacing issues
- I FEEL IT IN MY CORE. Afterglow very gentle.

The Boys Show 7.9/10

- A realistic depiction of superheroes
- What if superman was a sociopath megalomaniac with a fragile ego
- Well crafted satire
- The characters are nice, especially butcher. Soldier Boy and Homelander especially.

Princess Mononoke 8.3/10

- Unconventional villain setup
- Very nice and beautiful, the ideas are really solid and the music is really like adventurous
- I thought it was interesting that there was no villain.
- The story plot was clear
- Mythical feeling?

Howls Moving Castle 7.4/10

- THE MUSIC SOUNDTRACK
- Not really sure the plot
- But so creative, so whimsical, so escapist.
- How could someone think of that? So abstract in a good way

November

Lord of the Rings 9/10

- The three series are the best trilogy out there, hands down. Tolkien was cooking.
- There is way too much to say here. The world is a bit escapist but so vast, there are little grimoires hiding on every rewatch and seeing the movie at a theater is like joy. The characters being the same made me connect with all of them and the content was just enjoyable.
- The themes are a bit innocent and dualistic but still touching on some societal themes I found nice.

Hamilton 8.2/10

- The music is memorable
- The history is interesting for portraying something I do not already know.
- It is mainly a musical
- But Burr is not a villain as well, that is great storytelling for what truly happened within history.
- The audacity, emotions, revenge, love, nostalgia, helplessness.

Whiplash 8/10

- Unconventional ending
- Banger quotes I still remember such as "The next Charlie Parker would never be discouraged"
- The trope is relatable and the sheer dedication is evident.
- Mindgames
- Bro can't be that mad

Earlier?

Berserk 8.7/10

- It's fking beautiful
- Guts' only friend is his sword, he finds a new family which is utterly destroyed by Griffith.
- Chasing your dreams at all costs. The pursuit of purpose
- Fate versus free will.
- Philosophy and human character.

Avatar 3 7/10

- I don't think it deserves a 7. The plot is really basic and honestly a continuation of the first two
- The world-building is beautiful, and what made it special for me was revisiting the lost world of Pandora and meeting old friends at the theater.
- We dream as one

Mission Impossible, Final Reckoning 6.4/10 (+0.7 for long-time running. I love the series)

- Insanely action packed.
- Edge of your seat, the stunts themselves are commendable
- The world-building and entire series continuity is nostalgic.
- There is not much depth beyond straight "mission" and "difficulty" and hype.

Gladiator 7.8/10

- YES
- It's like a common enemy story but done beautifully and realistically I feel like part of ancient ROME.

2025?

Life is Beautiful 8/10

- Innocent and reminds me of Setsuko and Seita.
- Hide from the little ones, because no child should have to go through the horrors of war.
- The song and princessa is beautiful
- The character's humor is undying until the very end.
- Star of David, a reminder of the horrors of war. The painted horse.

The Gorge 6/10

- Two people who unexpectedly fall in love while guarding a top-secret mission base
- Genuinely creative, and probably a hint of realistic events in there.
- Wonder of the world-building but the relationship is so fleeting at the same time.
- There's basically one obvious "bad guy" though.

Who knows

Free Solo 6/10

- I find Alex Honnold Intriguing
- It was definitely breath-stopping
- It was definitely a journey.
- And he sums it up well how he practiced so much there's little risk and people take what they want to take away from it. He fit his niche.
- There wasn't really much of a movie, it was more a documentary with a cohesive narrative.